

STARTUP MATURITY ATLAS

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"Make no small plans." — Daniel Burnham

"The best founders don't just build products—they build systems for learning faster than everyone else."

START HERE: TAKE THE INTERACTIVE ASSESSMENT

Before diving into this guide, discover exactly where you are.

We've built an interactive diagnostic tool that asks you 12 questions across 4 dimensions and tells you:

- Your current phase in each dimension (Validate → Systematize → Scale)
- Personalized resource recommendations
- Visual matrix showing your startup's maturity profile

→ chistartuphub.com/assessment

Takes 3 minutes. Results are instant. No signup required.

This PDF is your reference companion. The Assessment is your compass.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Think of your startup like a house. You wouldn't install the roof before pouring the foundation. This atlas helps you identify which "floor" you're building and what support beams need strengthening.

Two ways to use this:

1. **Diagnostic** — Find where you are, identify gaps
2. **Roadmap** — See what comes next, prepare ahead

THE MATURITY MATRIX

Your startup operates across **4 dimensions**. Each dimension evolves through **3 phases**.

	PHASE 1 FOUNDATION	PHASE 2 TRACTION	PHASE 3 SCALE
PRODUCT	Problem-Fit	Product-Market Fit	Market Expansion
TEAM	Solo/ Co-founders	Core Team (3-10)	Organization Building
FUNDING	Bootstrapping/	Seed/	Series A+

	Pre-seed	Angel	
OPERATIONS	Manual/ Ad-hoc	Process Building	Automated Systems

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION

You're testing whether the problem is real and worth solving.

PRODUCT — Problem-Fit

The Question: Do people actually have this problem?

You're Here If:

- ☐ You're talking to potential customers weekly
- ☐ You have a hypothesis but no paying customers yet
- ☐ Your "product" might just be a landing page or prototype

Warning Signs:

- Building features no one asked for
- Avoiding customer conversations
- Assuming you know what people want

Key Metrics:

- Customer interviews completed: aim for 50+
- Problem validation: Can you describe the pain in their words?
- Willingness to pay: Have 3+ people said "I would pay for this"?

TEAM — Solo/Co-founders

The Question: Do you have the right people to start this journey?

You're Here If:

- ☐ 1-2 founders doing everything
- ☐ Roles are fluid, everyone does everything
- ☐ No formal structure yet

Warning Signs:

- Co-founder conflicts brewing (have hard conversations early)
- Skill gaps in product, tech, or business
- No written agreements between founders

Action Items:

- ☐ Draft co-founder agreement (equity, roles, vesting)
- ☐ Identify your #1 skill gap

- ☐ Define who makes final decisions in each area
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FUNDING — Bootstrapping/Pre-seed

The Question: Can you get to the next milestone without running out of runway?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Self-funded or friends & family money
- ☐ <\$100K raised total
- ☐ 6-12 months of runway

Warning Signs:

- Spending on things that don't help you learn
- No clear milestones for next funding
- Raising too early (before you can answer basic questions)

Chicago Resources:

- Illinois SBDC (free business counseling)
 - Chicago:Blend pre-accelerator
 - SCORE Chicago mentorship
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OPERATIONS — Manual/Ad-hoc

The Question: Are you capturing what you're learning?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Processes exist in your head, not documented
- ☐ Using free/cheap tools (Notion, Google Sheets)
- ☐ No formal metrics tracking

Warning Signs:

- Reinventing the wheel each time
- Can't answer "what did you learn last week?"
- Losing track of customer conversations

Starter Stack:

- Communication: Slack (free tier)
 - Docs: Notion or Google Docs
 - CRM: Spreadsheet or HubSpot (free)
 - Analytics: Basic Google Analytics
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PHASE 2: TRACTION

You've found something that works. Now make it repeatable.

PRODUCT — Product-Market Fit

The Question: Do people love this enough to pay and tell others?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Revenue is growing (even if small)
- ☐ Users are sticking around (retention > 40%)
- ☐ Word-of-mouth is happening

Warning Signs:

- Users sign up but don't come back
- Sales require heavy discounting
- Every customer wants something different

PMF Indicators:

- NPS > 40
 - Users angry when product is down
 - Organic growth happening
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TEAM — Core Team (3-10)

The Question: Can you build a team that executes without you in every meeting?

You're Here If:

- ☐ First 3-5 employees hired
- ☐ Some specialization emerging
- ☐ Starting to think about culture

Warning Signs:

- Founder doing everything still
- First hires aren't working out
- No one can make decisions without you

Action Items:

- ☐ Document your values (actually live them)
 - ☐ Create onboarding process
 - ☐ Delegate one major area completely
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FUNDING — Seed/Angel

The Question: Can you raise enough to find repeatable growth?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Raising \$500K-\$2M

- ☐ Have some traction to show
- ☐ Pitching to angels and seed VCs

Warning Signs:

- Raising on story alone (need some metrics)
- Taking bad terms out of desperation
- Not tracking where every dollar goes

Chicago Investors (Seed Stage):

- Chicago Ventures
- M25
- Hyde Park Venture Partners
- LOUD Capital
- Lightbank

OPERATIONS — Process Building

The Question: Can someone else do this task without you explaining it?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Some processes documented
- ☐ Starting to use real tools (CRM, project management)
- ☐ Basic metrics dashboards exist

Warning Signs:

- Knowledge lives only in people's heads
- New hires take months to become productive
- Same mistakes happening repeatedly

Process Priorities:

1. Sales process (lead → close)
2. Customer support workflow
3. Product development cycle
4. Hiring process

PHASE 3: SCALE

You know what works. Now do it 10x bigger.

PRODUCT — Market Expansion

The Question: Can this work in new segments or markets?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Core product stable

- ☐ Exploring adjacent markets
- ☐ Building platform/ecosystem plays

Warning Signs:

- Expanding before core is solid
 - Losing focus on what made you successful
 - Technical debt slowing everything down
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TEAM — Organization Building

The Question: Can you build a company that outlasts any individual?

You're Here If:

- ☐ 20+ employees
- ☐ Multiple layers of management
- ☐ Formal HR and operations

Warning Signs:

- Culture diluting with growth
 - Communication breaking down
 - A-players leaving
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FUNDING — Series A+

The Question: Can you deploy large amounts of capital efficiently?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Raising \$5M+
- ☐ Clear path to \$10M+ ARR
- ☐ Institutional investors leading

Chicago Growth Investors:

- Pritzker Group
 - OCA Ventures
 - Valor Equity Partners
 - Jump Capital
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OPERATIONS — Automated Systems

The Question: Do your systems scale without linear headcount growth?

You're Here If:

- ☐ Significant automation in place
- ☐ Data-driven decision making

- ☐ Predictable, repeatable processes
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THE DIAGNOSTIC TOOL

Prefer the interactive version? → chistartuphub.com/assessment

Answer honestly for each dimension:

PRODUCT

- Can you describe your ICP in one sentence?
- What's your activation rate? Retention rate?
- Where does your growth come from?

TEAM

- Who makes final decisions in each area?
- How long until a new hire is productive?
- What happens if a key person leaves?

FUNDING

- How many months of runway?
- What milestones unlock next funding?
- What's your CAC and LTV?

OPERATIONS

- Can someone else do your job for a week?
 - How long to onboard a new employee?
 - Where do you waste the most time?
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FOUNDER FOCUS CHECKLIST

Weekly

- ☐ Talk to at least 3 customers
- ☐ Review key metrics dashboard
- ☐ One-on-ones with direct reports
- ☐ Update investors (if applicable)

Monthly

- ☐ Full team all-hands
- ☐ Financial review (cash position)
- ☐ Competitive landscape check
- ☐ Personal energy audit

Quarterly

- ☐ OKR/goal setting
 - ☐ Board meeting (if applicable)
 - ☐ Team retrospective
 - ☐ Strategic planning
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AI TOOLS FOR FOUNDERS

Research & Analysis

- **ChatGPT/Claude** — Customer interview synthesis, market research
- **Perplexity** — Real-time market data, competitor analysis
- **Gong/Fireflies** — Call recording and analysis

Content & Marketing

- **Jasper** — Marketing copy
- **Midjourney** — Visual assets
- **Descript** — Video/podcast editing

Development

- **GitHub Copilot** — Code assistance
- **Cursor** — AI-native IDE
- **Vercel v0** — UI prototyping

Operations

- **Notion AI** — Documentation
 - **Zapier** — Workflow automation
 - **Otter.ai** — Meeting transcription
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CHICAGO ECOSYSTEM RESOURCES

Explore the full directory: chistartuphub.com/directory

Accelerators & Incubators

- **1871** — Tech/entrepreneurship center
- **mHUB** — Manufacturing/hardtech
- **MATTER** — Healthcare innovation
- **The Hatchery** — Food & beverage
- **2112** — Creative industries
- **Techstars Chicago** — Accelerator program

→ More at chistartuphub.com/accelerators-incubators

Funding Sources

- **Illinois Ventures** — University spin-outs
- **Chicagoland Entrepreneurial Center**
- **Illinois SBIR/STTR** — Grant funding
- **Keiretsu Forum Chicago** — Angel network

→ More at chistartuphub.com/funding

Community

- **Technori** — Startup events
- **Chicago Founders Network**
- **Built In Chicago** — Tech community
- **ChiStartupHub.com** — Your ecosystem hub

→ Connect with founders: chistartuphub.com/community

GLOSSARY

ARR — Annual Recurring Revenue

Burn Rate — Monthly cash spent

CAC — Customer Acquisition Cost (cost to get one customer)

Churn — Rate at which customers leave

ICP — Ideal Customer Profile

LTV — Lifetime Value (total revenue from one customer)

MRR — Monthly Recurring Revenue

NPS — Net Promoter Score (would customers recommend you?)

PMF — Product-Market Fit

Runway — Months of cash remaining

TAM/SAM/SOM — Total/Serviceable/Obtainable Market

Unit Economics — Profit per customer after all costs

FINAL THOUGHTS

Building a startup is hard. You'll feel lost most days. That's normal.

The founders who succeed aren't smarter—they're better at:

1. **Learning fast** — Talk to customers obsessively
2. **Admitting mistakes** — Kill ideas that aren't working
3. **Building support** — Find mentors, co-founders, community

This atlas is a compass, not a map. Your journey will look different. The phases won't be linear. You'll skip ahead in some areas and fall behind in others.

That's the game. Keep playing.

ChiStartupHub — Connecting Chicago's Startup Ecosystem

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→ **Take the Interactive Assessment:** chistartuphub.com/assessment

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